ONE TEAM, ONE COUNTRY, ONE MASCULINITY?

Exploring Hybrid Masculinity Among South African Male Rugby Players



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Introduction

Rugby has been a politicised sport that functions as a male preserve and 'third place' between racial and national identities, classes and masculinities to promote social cohesion, dominance, segregation, and transformation



- Early 20th century – reduces conflict and cultivate social cohesion between the British and Afrikaans after the Anglo-Boer war



- 1948 – political power shift from the Union Party to the Herenigde Nasionale Party, promoting Afrikaaner nationalism and masculinity in rugby and the country

- 1990s – Chester Williams becomes the first coloured Springbok following the end of apartheid. In the 1995 Rugby World Cup, the team played under the slogan, “One Team, One Country” and the Rainbow Nation idea emerges.



RATIONALE

The Rainbow Nation

Interculturalism

promotes a unified South African identity, which would be recognised as the country re-entered the global community. However, this decontextualised interpretation ignores the diversity and the remnant inequalities between groups (Baines, 1998).

Multiculturalism

The second version of the Rainbow Nation, popularised by Desmond Tutu, aligns with multiculturalism and embraces plurality and equality (Baines, 1998; Levrau & Loobuyck, 2018). However, this understanding, which manifests as transformation and affirmative action, emphasises and exaggerates social divisions in the name of group autonomy decolonisation (Levrau & Loobuyck, 2018; Penrose, 2017).





Rationale

As the sport grows more heterogeneous, this means plural masculinities, previously ranked in the Apartheid system, interact and are influenced by each other and the Rainbow Nation (Morrell et al., 2013; Nauright & Chandler, 1996). While discussions and praxis of the Rainbow Nation attempt to correct the political, racial and economic inequalities, it often neglects to discuss interactions and inequalities between South Africans' intersecting identities.

Aim: To discuss the Rainbow Nation, its influence and (in)effectiveness through a gendered lens to highlight how the discourse and racial integration affect intersecting identities, such as gender constructions among male rugby players.

Theoretical Frameworks

Hybrid Masculinity

- Emerged from Connell's (1987) hegemonic masculinity. However, Morrell et al. (2013) critique the overemphasis of the theory in South African research
- Hybrid masculinity refers to the selective performance and incorporation of characteristics of alternative or subordinate masculinities by men who attempt to symbolically distance themselves from hegemonic masculinity.
- A better-suited theory from hegemonic masculinity for the ever-changing construction of masculine identities among men in the Rainbow Nation
- **Unidirectional**

Hybridity

- Hybridity argues that identities, such as masculinity, are socially constructed and contingent on historical events (Bhabha, 2004).
- Interactions in these spaces are often ambivalent and can result in:
  1) domination
  2) deconstruction
  3) negotiation and creativity
- uncritical framing of hybridity as a progressive concept



Literature *Review*

1. Rugby as a “masculine flagship sport” (Pelak, 2010, p. 64, as cited in Rothman et al. 2023), where players perform and embody orthodox hegemonic masculinity predicated on homophobia, heteronormativity, misogyny, aggression and bravado (Anderson, 2008; Morrell, 2017; Nauright & Chandler, 1996; Pringle, 2024; Rothmann et al., 2023).

2. However, globalisation, democratisation and the international move towards equality and inclusion spill over into rugby, challenging the notion of the sport as a male preserve.

3. Rugby moving towards inclusive masculinity vs. reconfiguring hierarchy through a hybrid masculinity





Is there an emerging hybrid masculinity due to discourses surrounding racial integration and the Rainbow Nation among South African male rugby players?

Methodology

1 Research Design

- exploratory qualitative research design
- social constructionism
- examine how male players use a combination of language, embodied performances, and discourses to negotiate, challenge, comply or maintain power relations in their

2 Participants and Recruitment

- 7 volunteer male rugby players from the Wits squad
- Purposive convenience and snowball sampling
- Team officer as a gatekeeper
- In the event of low response rates, an alternative multicultural rugby team will be approached.



3 Data Collection

- Semi-structured interviews with 7 players lasting between 45 and 60 minutes.

4 Instruments

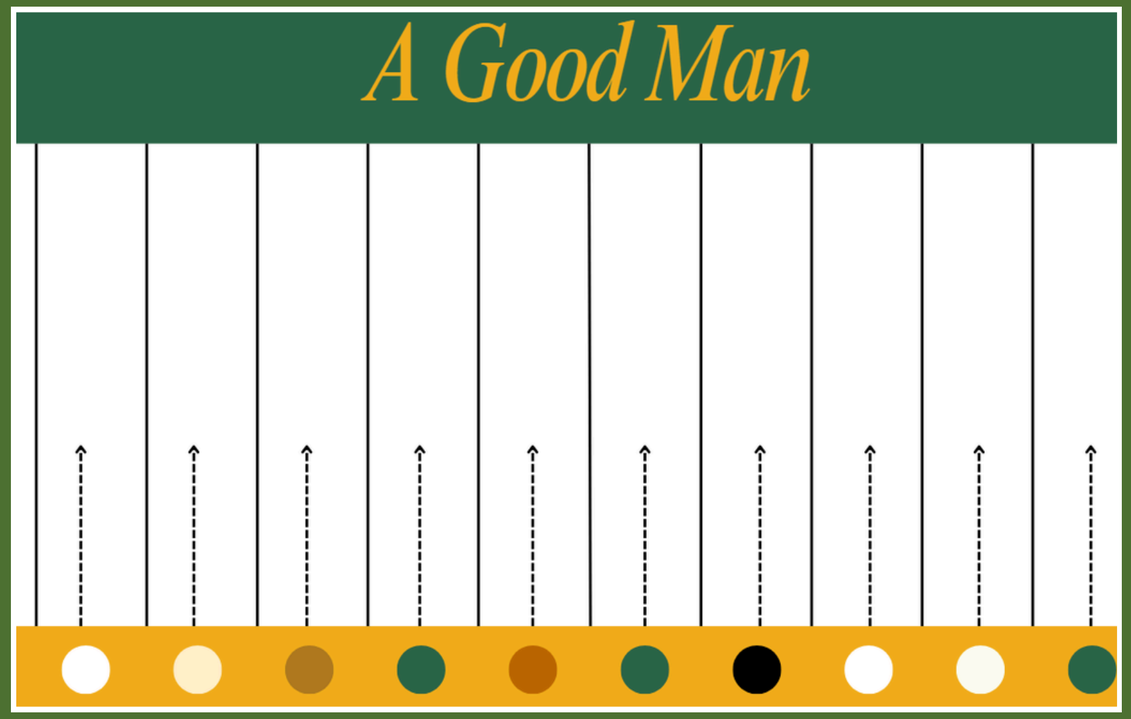
- Demographic information form
- Self-developed guide designed using Kallio et al.'s (2016) framework.

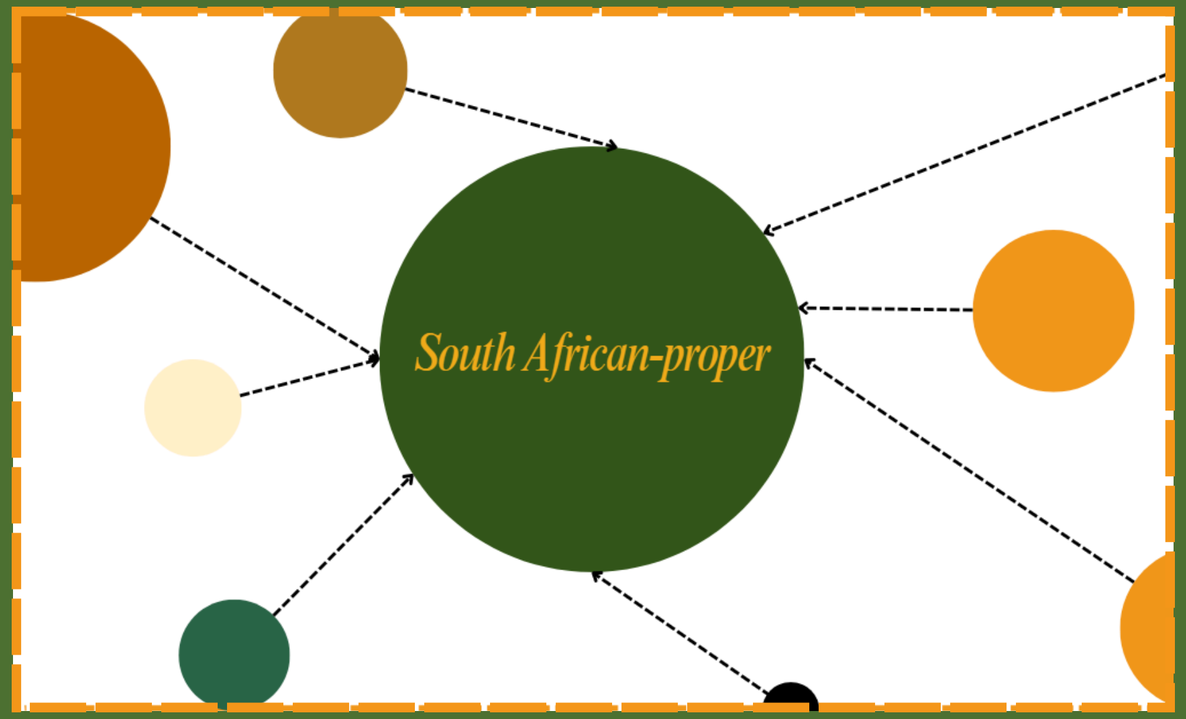
5 Data Analysis

- Audio recordings from individual semistructured interviews and transcribe them verbatim using the transcript system in adapted from Schlegoff/Sacks transcription system.
- Transcripts analysed in Obsidian.md
- Code meaning approach
- Critical discourse analysis

01 Creating Arenas

02 Differentiation





03 Construction

04 Hierarchy

Conclusion

Despite these limitations, the study argues for the need for transformation initiatives, guided by one interpretation of the Rainbow Nation, to go beyond economic issues towards a multilevel form of praxis that promotes equality among cultural groups, sexual and gender identities and (dis)abilities in South Africa



Q&A



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